



THE LONG VIEW

On Freedom and the Systems That Shape Us

A 6-Part Series

S E R I E S O V E R V I E W

This series explores a single question from six different angles: how do the systems around us shape our behavior, our thinking, and our freedom — and is there a better way?

Article 1 — How Systems Shape You Without You Noticing

Article 2 — Why Your Money Is Working Against You

Article 3 — Who Taught You How to Think?

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A N O T E B E F O R E W E B E G I N

I already knew where this was going.

I've understood Bitcoin for what it is for a while now. Not as a speculation. Not as a technology trend. As a response to something real — a monetary system designed so that no government can expand its supply, no institution can change its rules, and no concentration of power can quietly take it away.

Once you see it that way, it's difficult to unsee.

The harder question was how to help others see it too.

Most people don't arrive at Bitcoin through the whitepaper. They arrive through a provocation — a moment when something about the world stops making sense. And one night, watching the news as Israel and the United States struck Iran, a provocation led me down the path to write this series. It didn't lead me to Bitcoin — but it helped me see a path that could possibly lead others there.

The restrictions on freedom in Iran are obvious. A regime that has imposed its will on its people for decades — visibly, forcefully, without apology.

But watching that, something else came into focus. We in the west are substantially more free than people in Iran. So why is it that I still feel like I constantly have to work to maintain that freedom? Who is imposing these restrictions? It can be more difficult to point a finger.

The most dangerous limits on freedom aren't the ones announced. They're the ones that go unnoticed — built into the systems we live within, shaping our choices before we've thought to question them.

You don't always need a corrupt leader to end up with less freedom. Sometimes the mechanism is subtler. A monetary system that quietly erodes savings. An education that never teaches you to question certain things. A social current that makes some ideas feel unreasonable before you've even examined them.

These are structures. And structures shape behavior in ways that feel like personal choice — even when the conditions were set by someone else entirely.

This series is my attempt to build the bridge — from that provocation to a deeper understanding. And to make the case that Bitcoin isn't just a financial instrument. It's the most serious answer yet to a question most people haven't thought to ask.

Zoom out to understand the present. Look forward to navigate the future. This is Long View.

— Long View

T H E P A T T E R N

How Systems Shape You Without You Noticing

The most powerful forces in your life rarely announce themselves.

Think about the last major financial decision you made. Maybe it was about saving, spending, or investing. You probably felt like you were making a free choice — weighing options, considering your values, deciding for yourself.

But here's a question worth sitting with: what shaped the options you were weighing in the first place?

Most of us living in the west would say we're free. And compared to much of the world, we are — substantially so. But there's a quieter question that's harder to answer: why does maintaining that freedom feel like constant work? Why does staying in place financially require more effort than it used to? Why does the range of real choices sometimes feel like it's narrowing, even when nothing dramatic has happened?

This series starts with an observation that sounds simple but gets more unsettling the longer you hold it: we don't just live within systems. Systems live within us.

"The environment is shaped... and individuals, often without realizing it, begin to adapt to it."

It Doesn't Feel Like Control

The interesting thing about systemic influence is that it rarely feels like influence. It feels like normal life.

If a monetary system erodes the value of savings, people adapt — some without noticing, some with frustration. Either way, the behavior was shaped by something external. The reasoning feels personal. The conditions were not.

None of this requires bad intentions from anyone. Systems shape behavior simply through their structure — through what they reward, what they penalize, and what they make feel normal.

The Gradual Shift

What makes this pattern worth paying attention to is how it accumulates over time.

One small adjustment to behavior doesn't change much. But over years and decades, the cumulative effect of adapting to your environment — without examining it — can result in a significantly narrower range of real choices.

And because each step felt reasonable, the destination is rarely questioned.

This series is an attempt to examine it. Not to argue that all systems are harmful — they're not. Systems are necessary. Coordination is valuable. Structure enables freedom as often as it limits it.

But the question is whether individuals remain meaningfully free within the systems they inhabit.

To make that question concrete, we have to start somewhere specific. And the most immediate system shaping most people's daily decisions — more than they usually realize — is money.

Key Takeaway Systems shape behavior not through force, but through structure — by setting the conditions within which individual choices are made. Understanding those conditions is the first step toward genuine freedom.

Next in the series: **Why Your Money Is Working Against You**

MONEY

Why Your Money Is Working Against You

It's not just a tool. It's a structure — and structures have consequences.

Think about everyday costs. In my lifetime — 1985 to 2026 — a basket of goods and services — food, electricity, clothing, transportation — that cost \$100 then costs \$267.15 today, according to the Bank of Canada's inflation calculator. The dollar didn't disappear. But it lost about 62.5% of its value. Quietly. Over time. Without any single moment you could point to and say: that's when it happened.

Now zoom out further. From 1926 to 2026 — one hundred years — that same \$100 basket costs \$1,803.26 today. The dollar didn't just lose value. It lost 94.5% of its value. What your great-grandparents held as savings is worth less than six cents on the dollar today.

Unlike housing — where demand, population growth, and interest rates all play a role — a broad basket of everyday goods and services gives a more consistent signal of purchasing power over time. The price increase isn't a market story. Your dollar simply buys less than it used to. That's not a fluctuation. That's the system working as designed.

This is monetary inflation. A measurable, structural feature of how modern currencies work — not an occasional accident.

The Invisible Tax

Money feels neutral. It's just a number. But the purchasing power of that number changes — and that change is not neutral at all.

When the supply of money expands faster than the goods and services it represents, each unit of money buys less. Savings erode. Fixed incomes shrink. The person who works hard and puts money aside finds, a decade later, that it buys far less than they expected.

This isn't accidental. It's structural. The ability to expand the money supply is a form of power — and that power is concentrated in relatively few institutions.

The 2008 financial crisis made this visible in a way that's hard to forget. Banks in the United States had taken on enormous risk through complex financial products tied to the housing market. When those bets collapsed, the US government created the

\$700 billion Troubled Asset Relief Program (TARP) to stabilize the financial system (US Treasury). Most of that money was eventually repaid — the banks survived. But over 9 million Americans lost their jobs between 2008 and 2010, and millions lost their homes to foreclosure. The institutions whose decisions caused the crisis were supported through it. Ordinary people absorbed the consequences of decisions made within a system they had no real voice in.

That asymmetry — where the risks of monetary decisions fall on those with power, and the consequences fall on those without it — is the structural point worth sitting with.

"If money loses value over time, saving becomes less attractive than spending. The system doesn't force this behavior. It just makes it feel rational."

How the Structure Shapes Behavior

Consider what a high-inflation monetary environment quietly encourages:

Spending now rather than saving for later. Borrowing rather than accumulating. Asset ownership (which hedges inflation) over cash savings (which don't). Risk-taking over patience.

None of these behaviors are irrational, given the structure. They're actually quite sensible. But they're sensible precisely because the structure makes them sensible. The system isn't forcing anyone to do anything. It's just making certain choices feel more natural than others.

And here's where it gets interesting: most people never examine the structure. They simply adapt to it — often without realizing the adaptation is happening.

What Would a Different Structure Look Like?

Imagine a monetary system with a fixed supply. No central authority controlling issuance. No ability to expand supply for political or economic convenience.

In that environment, saving would make sense again. Patience would be rewarded. Long-term thinking would have structural support, not just moral encouragement.

This is one of the core arguments for Bitcoin — not just as an investment, but as an alternative monetary structure. One where the rules are transparent, fixed, and not subject to the decisions of any institution.

Whether or not you find that argument convincing, it's worth sitting with this: the monetary system has been shaping your behavior for your entire adult life. And yet most people were never taught how it works.

Which raises a harder question. If the system shapes behavior — but education never gave you the tools to examine the system — how would you even know to look? That's not a financial question anymore. It's an education question.

Key Takeaway Money isn't neutral. The structure of a monetary system shapes behavior just as reliably as any law — but far less visibly. Understanding that structure is the beginning of financial self-awareness.

Sources

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Canadian MoneySaver — 'The Evolution of Canadian Home Prices' — inflation-adjusted home price data showing ~2% real annual growth (canadianmoneysaver.ca)

US Treasury / TARP — Troubled Asset Relief Program summary; \$700 billion authorized, most repaid; 9 million jobs lost 2008–2010 (treasury.gov, GAO)

Next in the series: **Who Taught You How to Think?**

E D U C A T I O N

Who Taught You How to Think?

Education shapes more than what we know. It shapes how we reason.

There's a question that rarely gets asked in school: why are we learning this, and who decided it was worth knowing?

Not in a cynical way — but genuinely. Educational systems don't just transmit knowledge. They transmit frameworks for making sense of the world. And those frameworks, once internalized, can be remarkably difficult to examine from the outside.

The Curriculum Isn't Neutral

Every educational system involves choices: what to include, what to leave out, which questions to treat as settled, and which to treat as open. These choices reflect values, assumptions, and priorities — often those of the institutions or societies that design the curriculum.

This doesn't make education harmful. It makes it human. Any attempt to teach anything involves selection and framing. The question is whether students are taught to notice the frame — or just to operate within it.

In most systems, it's the latter.

"Thinking doesn't happen in isolation. It happens within systems. And if that's true — how often do we actually question the structure that shaped the way we think?"

What Gets Left Out

Consider what most people are never formally taught: how monetary systems work. How money is created. What inflation actually is and who controls it. The history of financial crises and their structural causes.

These aren't obscure topics. They affect every person who earns, saves, or spends. But they're largely absent from standard education. And their absence isn't neutral — it shapes what questions people think to ask.

Someone who has never been taught to examine monetary systems is less likely to question them. Not because they're incapable of critical thought, but because they've never been handed the tools for this particular inquiry.

The Value of Unlearning

Some of the most interesting intellectual work involves not just learning new things, but noticing assumptions you didn't know you had.

This is harder than it sounds. Assumptions that feel like common sense are precisely the ones that are most difficult to see. They're invisible because they feel like reality, not like a perspective.

But the ability to examine inherited frameworks — rather than just operate within them — is one of the most practically useful capacities a person can develop. It's the difference between thinking within a system and thinking about it.

There's a catch, though. Even if you develop that capacity individually, you don't think in isolation. You think inside a society — with its own currents, its own consensus, its own quiet pressure toward certain conclusions and away from others. Individual critical thinking and collective conformity are in tension. That tension is where we go next.

Key Takeaway Education shapes not just what we know, but the questions we think to ask. Building genuine intellectual freedom means developing the habit of examining frameworks — not just operating within them.

Next in the series: **The Crowd and the Individual**

S O C I E T Y

The Crowd and the Individual

Democracy is one of the best systems we've found. That doesn't mean the tension disappears.

Most of us believe, at some level, that individuals should be free to make their own choices — about their values, their lives, their futures.

Most of us also believe that societies need coordination. Common rules. Shared direction. Ways of making collective decisions.

Both of these beliefs are reasonable. But they exist in tension with each other. And that tension is worth examining.

The Quiet Pull of Consensus

In any group — a family, a workplace, a society — there's a current. A sense of which direction things are moving. Which views are acceptable. Which questions are reasonable to ask.

This current doesn't usually enforce itself through force. It enforces itself through something subtler: the social cost of swimming against it. The raised eyebrow. The sense of being out of step. The feeling that your position requires more justification than the consensus view does.

Over time, this can shape what people actually believe, not just what they say. When certain ideas become so normal that their alternatives feel strange, the range of genuine thought starts to narrow.

"When the collective moves in one direction, what happens to the individual who doesn't?"

The Majority Isn't Always Right

History offers no shortage of examples where majority opinion was wrong — and where the people who challenged it faced significant social pressure to conform.

This isn't an argument against democracy. It's an argument for protecting the space within democracies where dissent, heterodox thinking, and minority views can survive. Not because they're always correct, but because their existence is what makes course correction possible.

A society where consensus is never challenged is one where errors compound rather than get corrected.

Opting Out vs. Opting In

One framing that clarifies the tension: the difference between systems you're born into and systems you choose.

Most of the major systems shaping your life — the currency you use, the laws you live under, the educational frameworks you were raised with — were not chosen by you. They were inherited.

This isn't inherently a problem. No one can choose the circumstances of their birth. But it does raise a question that the first four articles of this series keep circling: what would it look like to actually choose the systems you participate in, rather than simply inheriting them?

That question has mostly been theoretical — until recently. Because something genuinely new has emerged: a monetary system that anyone can opt into voluntarily, that operates without a central authority, and whose rules no government can change. It doesn't solve everything. But it represents a different kind of answer to the problem we've been describing.

Key Takeaway Collective systems are necessary, but they carry a gravitational pull toward conformity. The capacity to think independently — and the existence of systems that allow genuine choice — is what keeps that pull from becoming total.

Next in the series: **Rules Without Rulers: What Bitcoin Actually Is**

BITCOIN

Rules Without Rulers: What Bitcoin Actually Is

Most people think Bitcoin is about money. It's really about something deeper.

If you've heard of Bitcoin, you've probably heard it described as a cryptocurrency, a speculative asset, digital gold, or a scam — depending on who's talking.

All of those descriptions miss something important.

Bitcoin is, at its core, an attempt to answer a specific question: can a monetary system operate without trusting any particular person or institution?

The Trust Problem

Every monetary system in history has required trust — in a government, a central bank, a commodity's scarcity, or some combination. That trust isn't irrational. Coordination requires shared belief.

But trust in institutions also means vulnerability to those institutions. Currencies can be inflated. Accounts can be frozen. Access can be revoked. The rules can change — and the people who can change them rarely face consequences for doing so.

Bitcoin's answer to this was radical: what if the rules were enforced by mathematics and distributed consensus, rather than by any authority?

"Rules without rulers. It takes power away from the few who can change the rules — and moves it toward a system that individuals can choose to opt into."

How It Actually Works (Simply)

Bitcoin has a fixed supply: 21 million coins, ever. No committee can vote to change it. No government can order more. It's written into the rules of the system itself.

But here's what makes it genuinely interesting: the rules hold not just because they're technically difficult to change, but because almost nobody who participates in the system would benefit from changing them. The fixed supply is a large part of why Bitcoin has value at all. Anyone who tried to inflate that supply would be diluting

their own holdings in the process. The rules and the self-interest of participants point in the same direction — which is rare, and worth noting.

Transactions are verified not by a central authority but by thousands of independent computers around the world, each following the same rules. No single entity controls the network. No permission is required to participate.

This is what "decentralized" actually means — not that it has no rules, but that those rules aren't owned by anyone.

Why It Matters Beyond the Price

Most monetary systems in history share a common feature: someone, somewhere, has the ability to change the rules. A government can devalue its currency. A central bank can expand the money supply. An institution can freeze an account. The people with that power rarely face consequences when they use it. The people without it absorb the results.

Bitcoin is an attempt to break that pattern — not by eliminating the system, but by designing one where the rules are transparent, fixed, and not subject to anyone's discretion. No committee. No override. No exceptions.

Money that quietly loses value, institutions that make decisions on your behalf without your input, structures that shape your behavior without your awareness — these aren't abstract concerns. They're the background conditions of most people's financial lives. Bitcoin is the first serious attempt to build a monetary system that addresses them at the root. You don't have to agree. But you owe it to yourself to understand it well enough to form your own view.

Key Takeaway Bitcoin isn't primarily about price. It's an experiment in building a monetary system that operates by transparent, fixed rules — without requiring trust in any institution or individual. That's a genuinely novel idea.

Sources

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Satoshi Nakamoto — *Bitcoin: A Peer-to-Peer Electronic Cash System* (bitcoin.org, 2008) — original *whitepaper*

Next in the series: **Freedom Isn't Given. It's Chosen.**

CLOSING ESSAY

Freedom Isn't Given. It's Chosen.

The hardest kind of freedom is the kind that requires something from you.

There's a comfortable version of freedom — one where it's something you have by default, something that exists until someone takes it from you. You just have to stop them from doing that, and you're free.

This series has been arguing for a more uncomfortable version.

One where freedom is something that requires active maintenance. Where the forces that diminish it are usually subtle rather than dramatic. And where, sometimes, the person most responsible for surrendering it is yourself.

The Slow Accumulation

Across money, education, and collective decision-making, the same pattern keeps appearing: systems don't usually reduce freedom through dramatic seizure. They do it gradually, through the accumulation of small adaptations that each feel reasonable.

And crucially — people often support these adaptations. Not because they're forced to, but because the adaptations make sense within the existing structure. The structure makes certain choices feel natural, and others feel strange. And most people follow what feels natural.

This is not a moral failing. It's human. But it does mean that the protection of individual freedom requires something more than just resisting external coercion.

"People can participate in systems that slowly reduce their own autonomy — not because they're forced to, but because they adapt to what feels normal."

The Responsibility That Comes With Freedom

Here's the tension that Bitcoin — and similar opt-in systems — expose: more freedom often means more responsibility.

A monetary system without a central authority means no one to bail you out. No institution to appeal to. No one else's fault if things go wrong. That's genuinely harder than delegating those decisions to someone else.

And many people, confronted with that reality, choose the delegation. Not because they're coerced, but because it's easier. More comfortable. More familiar.

That's a legitimate choice. But it's worth making it consciously — knowing what you're trading, and why.

What Examining the Structure Looks Like

The practical implication of everything in this series is actually quite simple: examine the systems you're in. Not necessarily to reject them — but to understand what they're doing, and what they're doing to you.

What does your monetary environment encourage? What assumptions did your education leave unexamined? Which of your beliefs feel like conclusions you've reached, and which feel more like water you've been swimming in?

These are uncomfortable questions. They don't have clean answers. But the act of asking them — genuinely, without already knowing the answer you want — is itself a form of freedom.

And unlike monetary systems or educational structures, it's one that no one else can provide for you.

The question is not whether systems will shape the future. They always do.

The question is whether the individual remains free within them.

— *The Long View Series*